WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

IRELAND

Europe

Information current as of November 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Dublin	Capital and Europe's leading English-speaking base for global technology, financial-services and aviation-leasing firms, home to the International Financial Services Centre	Technology, financial services, aircraft leasing, professional services
Cork	Second city and centre of Ireland's pharmaceutical and biopharma cluster, with a deep-water port and established US multinationals	Pharmaceuticals, technology, food, maritime
Galway and the West	Global medical-technology cluster with strong university research links	Medical devices, life sciences, digital
Limerick and Shannon	Mid-West hub with Shannon airport, the Shannon Free Zone and a growing manufacturing base	Aviation services, advanced manufacturing, life sciences
Kildare (Leixlip) and the Dublin commuter belt	Home to major semiconductor and technology operations close to Dublin's talent pool	Semiconductors, data and technology
Waterford and the South East	Regional city with life-sciences and engineering employers and port access to continental Europe	Life sciences, engineering, financial services

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- IDA Ireland, the state inward-investment agency, provides site, grant, R&D and talent support; it approved a record 323 investments in 2025, 57% of them outside Dublin
- Corporation tax of 12.5% on trading income, with a 15% minimum rate under the EU Pillar Two rules for groups with revenue of €750 million or more
- IDA grants for capital, R&D, training and employment, plus R&D tax relief, for qualifying projects across all regions
- Euro-area membership: the euro is the national currency, with free movement of capital under EU rules
- EU single-market membership, with Ireland the only English-speaking common-law jurisdiction in the euro area
- Central Bank of Ireland authorisation for banks, funds, insurers and payment firms, giving passporting rights across the EU
- Shannon Free Zone and regional IDA business parks offering serviced sites for manufacturing and services

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Ireland in November 2026 remains one of Europe's most successful destinations for foreign direct investment, combining euro-area membership, an English-speaking common-law system and a long record of hosting global technology and life-sciences companies. GDP grew 8.0% in 2025, and modified domestic demand, the best measure of the domestic economy, rose 4.7%; it grew 3.1% in the first half of 2026. Multinational output drove GDP up 3.9% year-on-year in the third quarter of 2026. IDA Ireland approved a record 323 investments in 2025, expected to create more than 15,300 jobs, with client firms employing 312,400 people and committing a record €2.5 billion to research and innovation. Public finances are strong: the 2025 general government surplus was €11.6 billion, 1.8% of GDP, and gross debt fell to 32.9% of GDP.

Ireland's main structural challenge is building the housing, energy and water infrastructure needed to keep pace with growth, while reducing reliance on a few large corporate taxpayers. The Fiscal Council estimates that three companies paid almost half of corporation tax in 2025 and that about €20 billion of receipts in 2026 may be transitory. The government is using these revenues to invest, with capital spending set to exceed €20 billion in 2027, and the new grid policy for data centres requires on-site generation or storage and new Irish renewable supply. Inflation rose to 4.0% in October 2026, driven by energy. US tariffs are a further consideration, but EU pharmaceutical exports to the US are capped at 15% under the EU-US arrangement, and many leading pharma firms with Irish plants have agreed terms that bring their rate to zero.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Housing and infrastructure capacity	Housing shortages and pressure on energy, water and transport networks can slow expansion and raise staff costs	Capital spending above €20 billion in 2027 targets these constraints; consider regional locations with IDA support
Grid access for data centres	A December 2025 policy requires new data centres to match demand with on-site generation or storage and source at least 80% renewable power	The policy restores a clear connection route; plan generation, storage and renewable supply from the outset
US trade policy	US tariffs on EU goods, including medicines, affect Ireland's largest export market	EU pharmaceutical exports are capped at 15% and many firms have zero-rate agreements; diversify markets and monitor US policy
Concentrated corporation tax receipts	A few multinationals account for a large share of tax revenue, creating fiscal exposure	The government is saving windfalls in long-term funds and using them for infrastructure, supporting stable policy
Cost of doing business	Inflation reached 4.0% in October 2026, and wages and property costs are high	Strong productivity, skills and the 12.5% rate offset costs; build energy and wage assumptions into plans
Global minimum tax	Large groups now pay at least 15% under Pillar Two rules	Ireland's offer rests on talent, stability and the R&D regime as well as tax; take advice on the Pillar Two position

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Ireland's risk profile is that of a stable, well-governed EU and euro-area member with a budget surplus, falling debt and a long record of policy continuity on foreign investment. Gross debt of 32.9% of GDP and a 2025 surplus of €11.6 billion give the state ample room to invest in infrastructure. The main risks are external and structural: US trade policy, the concentration of corporation tax in a small number of firms, and capacity limits in housing, energy and water. Each is being addressed, through the 15% cap on EU pharmaceutical tariffs, the saving of windfall receipts and record capital investment. Inflation of 4.0% in October 2026 and higher ECB rates, with the deposit rate at 2.50%, add to costs. There are no sanctions or legal restrictions specific to Ireland beyond those applying across the EU, and the government formed in January 2025 under Taoiseach Micheál Martin provides continuity.

MARKET ACCESS

As an EU member, Ireland gives investors tariff-free access to the EU single market of some 450 million people and to all the EU's free trade agreements, with WTO membership and the EU's common trade policy governing trade with third countries. As the only English-speaking common-law country in the euro area, it is a natural European base for US, UK and Asian companies, and it shares a Common Travel Area with the United Kingdom. Under the Windsor Framework, goods move freely across the border with Northern Ireland. The United States is Ireland's largest export market, led by pharmaceuticals, chemicals and medical devices, and EU exports to the US are covered by the EU-US arrangement that caps most tariffs at 15%. Dublin, Cork, Shannon and Rosslare connect Ireland with Britain, continental Europe and North America.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Department of the Taoiseach (Taoiseach Micheál Martin)	Leads the coalition government formed in January 2025 and sets national economic strategy	Primary reference point for strategic investment and policy
IDA Ireland	State inward-investment agency; supports 312,400 jobs in client companies and leads incentive and site negotiations	Standard first point of contact for market entry
Central Bank of Ireland	Member of the Eurosystem whose governor sits on the ECB Governing Council; authorises and supervises banks, funds, insurers and payment firms	Key counterpart for financial-services licensing
Department of Finance (Tánaiste and Minister Simon Harris)	Leads tax policy, including corporation tax and Pillar Two, and delivered Budget 2027 on 6 October 2026	Counterpart on tax and fiscal matters
Department of Public Expenditure, Infrastructure, Public Services, Reform and Digitalisation (Minister Jack Chambers)	Oversees the National Development Plan and capital investment of more than €20 billion in 2027	Relevant for infrastructure and public-private partnership opportunities
Enterprise Ireland	Agency for Irish-owned exporters and start-ups	Route to local partners, suppliers and acquisition targets
Commission for Regulation of Utilities and EirGrid	Set grid connection rules and capacity for data centres and other large energy users	Essential for data-centre and energy-intensive projects

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The American Chamber of Commerce Ireland, the British Irish Chamber of Commerce, Ibec (the main employers' body), Chambers Ireland and the Dublin Chamber are the principal business networks, with regular dialogue with government on tax, infrastructure and skills. IDA Ireland and Enterprise Ireland maintain international offices and run investor and trade programmes, and sector groups such as Biopharmachem Ireland and the Irish Medtech Association connect investors with the life-sciences ecosystem. The European Investment Bank is an active lender for infrastructure and housing, and the Ireland Strategic Investment Fund co-invests alongside private capital. Embassies of major partners maintain commercial sections that provide introductions.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Ireland suits investors seeking an English-speaking, common-law base inside the EU and the euro area: pharmaceutical, biotech and medical-technology companies building on the Cork, Galway and Dublin clusters; technology, software and semiconductor firms drawing on Ireland's talent pool; financial-services, fund and aircraft-leasing businesses using Central Bank of Ireland authorisation to serve the EU; data-centre and energy investors able to meet the new grid rules; and infrastructure and housing investors partnering with a state committing more than €20 billion a year to capital projects.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage IDA Ireland early
Open dialogue with IDA Ireland on site options, grants, R&D support and regional locations before finalising a location decision.

STEP 2: Confirm the tax position
Take advice on the 12.5% rate, the 15% Pillar Two minimum for large groups and R&D relief, and model the effective rate.

STEP 3: Secure grid, water and planning capacity
For energy-intensive or large sites, engage EirGrid, the utilities regulator and local authorities early on connection and planning.

STEP 4: Plan for talent and housing
Assess staff availability, housing and commuting, and consider regional locations where IDA support is strongest.

STEP 5: Map US trade exposure
Review tariff exposure on exports to the US and use the EU-US arrangement and company-level agreements where they apply.